The immigrants from Germany were often made fun of in the 1930s and 1940s by the then great majority of Jewish inhabitants of Eretz Israel of Polish or Russian origin. They were so stiff in the eyes of the locals, with such strange (polite) manners and what not. At the outset many of them had to work wherever they could, for example, on building sites. When you approached such a site you thought you heard the strange sound of a steam engine: “Bitte schön, Herr Doktor, danke schön, Herr Doktor” … In fact, these *yekes* formed from the outset the intellectual elite of the country; they set up, among other things, the Jewish judicial bureaucracy within the British mandatory system and, later on, after the creation of the State of Israel, an outstanding judiciary and Supreme Court. And, indeed, after 1948, many of the top members of the legal establishment were taught and then chosen from within that restricted pool, to fill the higher positions of the Israeli system. They were usually highly regarded and no professional objections were raised against them over the years. Could the selection have been different in due time as potential “Moroccan” candidates came of age? I am unable to tell. Now the battle over appointments to the Supreme Court may start again, and ethnic arguments will lurk once more behind the political and legal ones.

I touched upon the periphery of the periphery of the legal system by pure chance. When I graduated from my high school in Netanya, in June 1950, I was a few months away from my army service and in the meantime had to find work. There were jobs for youngsters like me at a reduced salary and one of them was that of messenger boy in the office of the legal adviser of the Foreign Ministry, at that time still located in Tel Aviv. The legal advisor was a jurist called Shabtai Rosenne, who was originally an English Jew. His second in command was American, and his young assistant, Canadian. The main secretary was of German origin and her own assistant, Mizrahit, but I do not remember from which country. This gives some idea of the palimpsest of nationalities of origin, in a small government office in Israel